Altaf—is a tactical move. Altaf has a strong support base in Poonch and Rajouri. J&K Apni Party and DPAP are expected to cut into the votes of older parties like NC and PDP. One can also read through these four candidates a tale of failed political alliances—a joint electoral venture between DPAP and Apni Party didn't materialise, and there is bad blood between I.N.D.I.A. bloc allies NC and PDP over fielding candidates for all three LS seats in the Valley. Moreover, the Congress is supporting NC candidates in the Valley.

The fragile situation in Anantnag-Rajouri has bettered the chances of the BJP. With Poonch and Rajouri as its focus, the BJP in recent days has

THOUGH ITS FOCUS IS ON POONCH AND RAJOURI, THE BJP IS POISED TO MAKE A MARK IN THE VALLEY

seen prominent Pahari leaders joining it, especially after the Narendra Modi government granted Scheduled Tribe status to Pahari ethnic groups in February. The party, which is coolly surveying the scene, seems to be in no hurry to name a candidate. Senior BJP leader and former deputy CM Kavinder Gupta admits that they are judging whether to field a candidate or give 'external' support to someone, barring NC or PDP. "We are not sure whether to contest from the constituency or not," he says.

"The main contest will be between the NC and the BJP, which has strategically given political reservation to Gujjars and now ST status to Paharis," says former Jammu University political science teacher Rekha Chowdhary. "I think Gujjars may vote for the NC and Paharis for the BJP. There will be a division of Muslim votes, but a consolidation of Hindu votes." Anantnag-Rajouri can well turn out to be a bellwether of Jammu & Kashmir's political future. ■


ANI

THE MISSUS CARD

Bihar's bahubalis muscle their way into the poll arena, mostly via their wives

By Amitabh Srivastava

Never did a bride get a better wedding gift as Kumari Anita did on April 9. The newly-wedded wife of convicted felon Ashok Mahto was given the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) ticket for the Munger Lok Sabha seat, where she will be taking on the Janata Dal (United)'s erstwhile president Rajiv Ranjan, a.k.a. Lalan Singh, come May 13.

Mahto married Anita on March 19, just three days after the Election Commission declared the poll dates. Released from jail last year after 17 years, Mahto's exploits—that include a high-profile jailbreak in 2002 and the alleged murder of then MP Rajo Singh in 2005—are said to have inspired the Netflix series, *Khakee: The Bihar Chapter*. Now out of jail, the bahubali of Munger was looking to reinvent himself in politics, except that poll regulations bar him from contesting personally for six years. Hence the quick wedding and the equally quick bestowal of ticket on the missus.

The spousal route is what Munna Shukla, a dreaded figure in the Muzaffarpur-Vaishali region, had also settled on. He said as much

KARNATAKA

GRANDSONS IN THE FRAY

Prajwal Revanna and Shreyas Patel fight for the legacies of their grandfathers—JD(S) patriarch H.D. Deve Gowda and Congress veteran G. Puttaswamy Gowda—in Hassan

By Ajay Sukumaran

It's nearly 9 pm and a small crowd at the village square in Malali is listening with rapt attention to 91-year-old H.D. Deve Gowda for an hour. Malali is in Holenarasipura taluk, the pocket borough of the Deve Gowda family in Karnataka's Hassan district. Deve Gowda is campaigning for his grandson Prajwal Revanna, 34, the Janata Dal (Secular) candidate from Hassan. In 2019, the Hassan Lok Sabha constituency was the only one the JD(S) won in the near-clean BJP sweep in Karnataka. The debutant Prajwal's victory wasn't surprising, for the Hassan seat had been in Deve Gowda's grip for three decades since 1991 when he was first elected to the Lok Sabha. Only on one occasion, between 1999 and 2004, was it